

The Potala Palace Today

The Potala Palace rises high on a hill in Lhasa. The fifth Dalai Lama began building it in 1645 on the site of a previous seventh century palace. It has a golden roof and two main parts—the Red Palace and the White Palace. The Red is a holy site and used for prayer and the study of Buddhism. The White contains many government offices.

The Potala holds many artifacts from Tibetan history and religion. Its rooms are decorated with gold and gems. They are filled with statues, paintings, and sculptures. Murals painted on the walls tell the story of Tibet.

There are no escalators or elevators up to the palace. Visitors climb more than four hundred steps to get there!